

Game Changer

A Bengal footballer breaks the mould and takes Kerala's ancient martial art form to a new terrain



MALLICK WITH HIS STUDENTS

By Sarbani Sen

Kal kundu chausti", (kick with your leg) commands Sariful Islam Mallick, and his students execute a block with their hands, tensing their right legs at the same time to deliver a forceful kick. Mallick, 28, who is a master in Kalarippayattu, the ancient martial art form of Kerala, is training cadets at the Police Training College (PTC), Barrackpore, a cantonment town 16 km north of Kolkata.

Regular practice of Kalari, as the art form is also known, "increases fitness, flexibility and stamina," says the Mallick, who went all the way to Kerala to master the traditional art form and is now promoting it in Bengal. A district-level football player from Bengal, Mallick first saw Kalari when he went to Kerala in 2001 for a match. Later, when health problems kept Mallick from his chosen game, he switched focus to Kalari. "I had a lung problem and was advised rest. I developed a keen interest in Kalari and toured Kerala," he says. Mallick's friends helped him with money but he had a tough time finding a teacher. "Gurus (masters) in Kerala

are rigid when it comes to sharing Kalari with an outsider but I was determined," he says. In 2003, Mallick joined the PKB Kalari Sangam Guru Vayur institute led by masters P.K. Balan Gurukkal and M.R. Jawhar Gurukkal. He stayed at the gurukul and also learnt Malayam. Soon, he achieved the title Gurukkal—master in Kalari. In 2007, Mallick even won a scholarship in the National Kalarippayattu talent hunt organised by the Union Ministry of Culture. "Winning the scholarship is an achievement for a person not from Kerala," he says.

This year, Mallick, along with his friends, launched PKB Kalari, Kolkata, a school teaching martial arts and dance to underprivileged children, at Howrah and Garia. While Mallick survives on the remuneration received from PTC, Kolkata's PKB Kalari is a self-funded organisation. "The right age to start learning this art is seven years. We are selecting talented young girls and boys from the eastern region. That would not only promote the art but help them get jobs. Girls will benefit as Kalari is also a very good form of self-defence," he says. ■